

ACTIVITY 15 — FACILITATOR GUIDE**PR Crisis Response Plan**

TYPE	DURATION	MAPS TO	TOPIC
Role Play	25 minutes	LU4	LU4 — Branding Effectiveness

Purpose of this activity

By the end of this activity learners will be able to apply public-relations tactics (LU4).

What learners produce

A same-night crisis-response script — public holding statement plus next-day interview line — rehearsed and benchmarked against a real crisis example.

Materials required

- Learner Worksheet (one per learner)
- Checklist (one per group)
- Flipchart or A3 sheet and markers
- The course slides for the scenario and framework
- Internet access where the activity calls for live research

Set-up

Groups of exactly 3 so every role is played. Distribute one worksheet per learner and one checklist per group. All 17 activities run on the same continuous Nimbus Wellness scenario, so remind learners of where this activity sits in that story before you start.

Scenario / briefing material

It's 9pm, the night before the founder's biggest relaunch media interview yet. A customer posts a video of her new Nimbus jar — from the new sustainable packaging line launched with the anniversary campaign — cracked and leaking product, captioned "the 'eco-friendly' packaging Nimbus is so proud of." Within two hours it has hundreds of shares and a wave of other customers replying with their own photos.

Operations thinks it may be a single bad batch from the new packaging supplier, but can't confirm numbers until morning. The journalist doing tomorrow's interview has already seen the thread and has emailed asking whether Nimbus knew about a defect before launch.

The founder wants to say nothing until Operations has the full facts — but the thread is growing every hour, and tomorrow's interview is unavoidable. Your group must decide what Nimbus does tonight, and what the spokesperson says tomorrow morning.

Roles

Assign one role per participant:

- **Spokesperson** — *Goal: Represent Nimbus publicly without over-promising.* Must decide what Nimbus can credibly say before every fact is confirmed, and how much to reveal in tomorrow's interview.
- **Journalist** — *Goal: Get a real, on-record answer for tomorrow's story.* Already has screenshots of the complaint thread and will ask directly whether Nimbus knew about the packaging issue before the relaunch.
- **Crisis-Response Lead** — *Goal: Coordinate the facts and the fix before Nimbus says anything publicly.* Is still confirming with Operations exactly how many units are affected, and whether it's a supplier fault or a Nimbus quality-control miss.

How to run it — step by step

#	Instruction to learners	Facilitator note
1	Assign the three roles. Spokesperson, Journalist, Crisis-Response Lead. The Journalist must genuinely press — a soft interview teaches nothing.	The instinct to wait for full facts is near-universal and is the core error — draw it out rather than correcting it early.
2	Separate what is known from what is assumed. Three columns: confirmed, suspected, unknown. Confirmed — jars are cracking and a thread is growing. Suspected — a single bad batch. Unknown — how many units, and whether it is supplier fault or Nimbus QC. You may only speak publicly to column one.	Watch for a Spokesperson blaming the supplier. Customers bought from Nimbus; deflection reads as evasion even when factually accurate.
3	Resolve the silence question. Debate whether saying nothing until Operations confirms everything is safer. It is not: a vacuum gets filled by the thread, and by morning the story is written without Nimbus in it. Acknowledging without concluding is the professional move.	
4	Draft tonight's holding statement. Write what Nimbus posts within hours. It must acknowledge, show the issue is being taken seriously, state what is being done now, and say when the next update comes — without admitting a cause nobody has confirmed. Say what is true, say what you are doing, say when you will say more.	
5	Prepare the Spokesperson's honest commitments. List what can be committed to before root cause is known: investigating, replacing affected units, updating by a stated time. These are process commitments, which are	

	always available; cause commitments are not.	
6	Run the interview. The Journalist asks directly whether Nimbus knew about a defect before launch. The Spokesperson must answer honestly without speculating. Watch for the two failure modes: over-promising a cause not yet confirmed, and stonewalling into a 'no comment' that reads as guilt.	
7	Keep internal and external in sync. Define how the Crisis-Response Lead and Spokesperson stay aligned — one shared fact-sheet, updated at a fixed cadence, from which all public statements are drawn. Crises are usually made worse by two people saying different true things.	
8	Benchmark against a real example. Compare your plan against a real 2024-25 brand crisis. Decide whether yours resembles the fast-and-transparent response or the delayed-and-silent one, and name which specific choice in your plan puts it in that category.	
9	Write the 24-hour commitment. State the follow-up Nimbus commits to publicly within 24 hours, and who owns it.	

Suggested timing

Minutes	Phase
4 min	Assign roles and establish what is actually known at 9pm
7 min	Decide tonight's holding response
7 min	Run the next-morning interview as a live role play
4 min	Benchmark against a real 2024-25 crisis
3 min	Write the 24-hour follow-up commitment

Total: 25 minutes

Discussion & decision prompts

1. Is staying silent until Operations confirms every fact actually the safer choice tonight, or does it leave a vacuum the thread will fill for Nimbus?
2. What can the Spokesperson honestly commit to in tomorrow's interview before the root cause is even confirmed?
3. How should the Crisis-Response Lead's internal fact-finding and the Spokesperson's public statement stay in sync without one getting ahead of the other?
4. What would Nimbus need to say and do in the first 24 hours to be judged as fast and transparent rather than defensive?

Debrief

Bring the class back together and draw out the learning:

- Ask two or three groups to show what they produced, not just what they concluded.
- Ask what surprised them — the gap between what they assumed and what they found.
- Link the activity explicitly back to LU4 — Branding Effectiveness.
- Remind learners this activity rehearses what the Case Study assessment will require.

Reflection questions:

- Did your Spokesperson end up promising more, or less, than Nimbus could actually deliver by morning?
- Where did the Journalist's questions expose a gap between what the Crisis-Response Lead knew and what the Spokesperson said?
- Looking at the Cracker Barrel and McDonald's examples, which pattern did your group's response end up closer to — and was that a deliberate choice?

Facilitator notes — what to watch for

- The instinct to wait for full facts is near-universal and is the core error — draw it out rather than correcting it early.
- Watch for a Spokesperson blaming the supplier. Customers bought from Nimbus; deflection reads as evasion even when factually accurate.

Success criterion

Every group can perform or narrate a same-night response that names what Nimbus confirms publicly within hours, what it says in tomorrow's interview, and a follow-up commitment — and can point to which real-world example (fast/transparent vs delayed/silent) their plan resembles.

Assessment link

This activity builds LU4 — Branding Effectiveness. All 17 activities are in-class activities assessed indirectly through the open-book Case Study (CS) component, which reuses the same techniques on the same continuous Nimbus Wellness scenario. Knowledge is assessed in the Written Assessment (WA-SAQ). Nothing is assessed that is not practised here or taught in the slides.